

Ferguson launches bid for re-election as Arlington clerk of court

by SCOTT McCAFFREY, Staff Writer
Mar 6, 2015



Arlington's constitutional officers: (from left) Commissioner of Revenue Ingrid Morroy, Clerk of the Circuit Court Paul Ferguson, Treasurer Carla de la Pava, Commonwealth's Attorney Theo Stamos and Sheriff Beth Arthur. All are unopposed in the November 2015 election. (Photo courtesy Karen Bate)

He has the best gig in local politics – only having to go to voters once every eight years – but Clerk of the Circuit Court Paul Ferguson hopes he has maintained the confidence of local residents during his first lengthy term in office.

Ferguson formally kicked off his re-election bid March 4 before the Arlington County Democratic Committee. It coincided with his 50th birthday.

("Can you believe he has an AARP card?" Democratic chairman Kip Malinosky said of the ever-youthful Ferguson. "Incredible. Incredible.")

Ferguson was serving on the County Board in 2007 when he was elected to succeed longtime clerk David Bell. The result was evolutionary rather than revolutionary, as Ferguson worked for incremental improvements to technology and customer service.

Over the past eight years, Ferguson was able to shorten the length of jury service from two weeks to one, and said he is eager to cut that down to either one day or one trial. "More jurors will be required," he said, but believes the end result will be a better experience for the public.

An Arlington native, Ferguson told Democrats that his re-election bid and milestone birthday provided a chance for "personal reflections."

"You took a chance on me," Ferguson said. "I've spent more than half my life with you."

Ferguson first became involved in the political committee in 1998, rising to serve as vice chairman of precinct operations before winning election to the County Board in 1995 on a ticket with Albert Eisenberg. He won re-election victories in 1999 with Charles Monroe and 2003 with Walter Tejada.

In 2007, as Bell's handpicked successor, Ferguson was elected clerk over Republican Mark Kelly. His County Board seat was inherited by Mary Hynes.

Ferguson is one of five Arlington constitutional officers on the Nov. 3 ballot. Like Commonwealth's Attorney Theo Stamos, his office also serves the city of Falls Church.

(Why do clerks of court have eight-year terms? They are a remnant of the era when Virginia was ruled by a succession of political machines, the Byrd machine being the best-known, they placed their men in those offices to control things in localities. Members of boards of supervisors and city councils came and went, but many clerks of court proved eternal.)

A longtime Fairlington resident, Ferguson and his wife Karen recently moved to a home just south of Arlington Boulevard. They have two sons.